



XNY/Star Max/GC Images

NICOLÁS Maduro and his wife, Cilia Flores, are escorted from a Manhattan helipad toward federal court.

Trump’s threats to launch attacks on 5 nations rattle allies and rivals

By MICHAEL WILNER
AND KATE LINTHICUM

WASHINGTON — Venezuela risks “a second strike” if its interim government doesn’t acquiesce to U.S. demands. Cuba is “ready to fall,” and Colombia is “very sick, too.”

Iran may get “hit very hard” if its government cracks down on protesters. And Denmark risks U.S. intervention, as well, because “we need Greenland,” President Trump said.

In just 37 minutes while speaking with reporters Sunday aboard Air Force One, Trump threatened to attack five countries, both allies and adversaries, with the might of the U.S. military — an extraordinary turn for a president who built his political career rejecting traditional conservative views on the exercise of American power and vowing to put America first.

The president’s threats come as a third of the U.S. naval fleet remains stationed in the Caribbean, af-

ter Trump launched a daring attack on Venezuela that seized its president, Nicolás Maduro, and his wife over the weekend.

The goal, U.S. officials said, was to show the Venezuelan government and the wider world what the American military is capable of — and to compel partners and foes alike to adhere to Trump’s demands through intimidation, rather than commit the U.S. military to more complex, conventional, long-term engagements.

It is the deployment of overwhelming and spectacular force in surgical military operations — Maduro’s capture, last year’s strikes against Iranian nuclear facilities, assassinations of Islamic State leadership and Iran’s top general in Iraq — that demonstrate Trump as a brazen leader willing to risk war, thereby effectively avoiding it, one Trump administration official said, explaining the president’s strategic thinking.

Yet experts and former

[See Threats, A3]

U.S. begins its battle in court with Maduro

Deposed president of Venezuela pleads not guilty to charges of cocaine trafficking.

By KEVIN RECTOR

Ousted Venezuelan leader Nicolás Maduro stood in a Manhattan courthouse Monday a captive criminal defendant: surrounded by heavy security, deprived of his power as a head of state and facing drug, weapon and conspiracy charges likely to keep him behind bars for years.

“I was captured,” he said in Spanish, before pleading not guilty during a brief arraignment. “I am a decent man, the president of my country.”

Just two days prior, more than 2,000 miles away in Caracas, Maduro was seated “atop a corrupt, illegitimate government that, for decades, has leveraged government power to protect and promote illegal activity, including drug trafficking,” according to a sweeping indictment unsealed Saturday.

What preceded Maduro’s swift downfall was not just his weekend capture in what President Trump called “one of the most stunning, effective and powerful displays of American military might” in U.S. history, but decades of partnership with “narco-terrorists” from Venezuela, Colombia and Mexico to enrich himself and his family through “massive-scale” cocaine trafficking, the indictment claims.

The allegations, built off a 2020 indictment, stretch back a quarter-century and implicate other Venezuelan leaders and Maduro’s wife and son. They suggest extensive coordination with notorious drug trafficking organizations and cartels from across the region and paint a world Trump himself has long worked to instill in the minds of Americans — one in which the nation’s southern neighbors are intentionally flooding the U.S. with lethal drugs and violent criminals, to the devastation of local communities.

It is a portrait of drugs, money and violence every bit as dramatic as the night-

[See Maduro, A3]

Chevron’s enduring Venezuelan legacy

California-founded heavyweight is only foreign petroleum firm in the oil-rich country.

By JACK DOLAN

Was it a spectacular drug bust? A big, beautiful business opportunity? Both? Whatever you call President Trump’s stunning military intervention in Venezuela over the weekend, one company with deep California ties stands to benefit: Chevron.

That’s because Venezuela has the largest proven oil reserves on the planet and Chevron — the international petroleum conglomerate with a massive refinery in El Segundo and headquartered, until recently, in San Ramon — is the only foreign oil company that has continued operating in Venezuela through decades of socialist revolution.

Other major oil companies, including Conoco-Phillips and Exxon Mobil, pulled out of Venezuela in

2007 when then-President Hugo Chávez required them to surrender majority ownership of their operations to the country’s state-controlled oil company, PDVSA.

But Chevron remained, playing the “long game,” according to industry analysts, hoping to someday resume reaping big profits from the investments the company started making there almost a century ago.

Venezuela is like Chevron’s “high-school sweetheart,” said Paasha Mahdavi, an associate professor of political science at UC Santa Barbara. “They’ve found a way to stay there through thick and thin.”

Looks like the company’s patience might finally pay off.

At his news conference

[See Chevron, A4]

Maduro tries to press his own case

The judge cuts him off, but the deposed leader continues making copious notes. **NATION, A5**

After Eaton fire, a deportation fight

Altadena resident was displaced by flames. Then ICE arrested her.

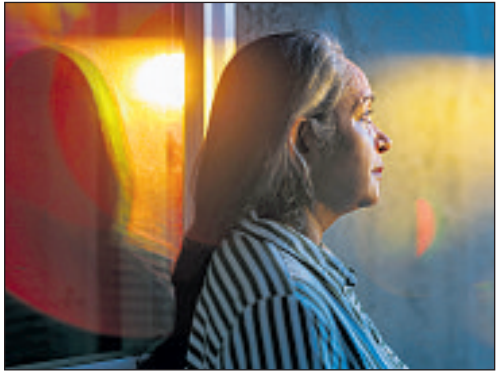
By RUBEN VIVES

There were no stars in the October sky. No moon that 64-year-old Masuma Khan could see from the narrow window of the California City Immigration Processing Center.

“No planes,” she said, recalling her confinement.

Once a prison, the facility in the Mojave Desert, located 67 miles east of Bakersfield, reopened in April to hold people in removal proceedings, including Khan.

It was not the kind of place where she imagined ending up —



GINA FERAZZI Los Angeles Times

MASUMA KHAN, 64, came to the U.S. in the 1990s to care for her ailing daughter.

not after living in the country for 28 years, caring for her daughter and surviving one of California’s deadliest wildfires, the Eaton fire.

Khan was fortunate not to have lost her west Altadena home to the Jan. 7 fire, which destroyed more than 9,000 structures and killed 19 people.

But in the months that followed, Khan faced another threat — deportation.

As fire recovery efforts were underway in Los Angeles, the Trump administration launched immigration raids in the city, hampering recovery efforts and cre-

[See Survivor, A6]



GENARO MOLINA Los Angeles Times

STUDENTS Kenny Rea-Cruz, left, and Jonathan Sepulveda assess a car in class.

Auto shop class is a dual engine, producing mechanics, free labor

By DANIEL MILLER

The workers’ uniforms are smudged with stains earned underneath a car, wrench in hand.

Their repair garage teems with an array of inoperable vehicles and twisted metal. One car’s wheels have been removed; another sports a mangled fender.

Here, the labor is free — and the mechanics are earning college credits.

Los Angeles Trade-Technical College offers the larg-

est community college auto repair program in the region, turning out graduates ready to work at dealership service centers, independent shops and the fleet departments of municipalities, among other areas.

The college has offered the training for decades, and its Automotive and Related Technology program has evolved with industry changes — including the advent of fuel injection, airbags and the rise of electric vehicles.

Other local community

colleges have auto programs, including Santa Monica College and El Camino College. But with more than 1,000 students, Trade-Tech’s program — which offers certificates and associate of science degrees — stands out for its size, said Jess Guerra, director of the college’s Transportation Workforce Institute, which includes the automotive program.

“One thing that makes us unique is the scale — we are the biggest in Los Angeles by

[See Mechanics, A14]

DOJ hire linked to dubious fraud case

By JAMES QUEALLY

Eric Neff’s tenure at the Los Angeles County district attorney’s office ended after he was placed on administrative leave in 2022 over accusations of misconduct in the prosecution of the CEO of Konnech, a software company that election conspiracy theorists said was in the thrall of the Chinese government.

Now, three years later, Neff is serving as one of the Trump administration’s top election watchdogs.

Late last year, his name began appearing on lawsuits filed by the U.S. Department of Justice’s Civil Rights Division, listed as “acting chief” of the voting section.

Neff’s appointment, first reported by Mother Jones, has prompted renewed scrutiny of his work at the L.A. County district attorney’s office.

The Times interviewed several of Neff’s former colleagues, who revealed new details about claims of misconduct that emerged from

[See Fraud, A7]



MYUNG J. CHUN Los Angeles Times

BREAK FROM THE RAIN

Diana Romero takes her dog out for a stroll. SoCal should stay dry for days. **CALIFORNIA, B1**

Hegseth moves to censure senator

Mark Kelly, a retired Navy captain, calls the Defense secretary’s action “un-American.” **NATION, A6**

Weather
More clouds than sun. L.A. Basin: 66/50. **B6**

Markets **A11**

Opinion Voices **A12**

Chargers seek different ending

Team is 0-2 in its previous playoff appearances in New England. **SPORTS, B10**

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